comprise less than 1 per cent of the Indian population. Both faiths popularized the wanderlust of asceticism and monastic ways of life, leading to new migratory circuits in addition to the pilgrimage routes associated with the pantheon of gods in Hindu philosophies. Also, both faiths were urban-based with a positive outlook towards trade and were heavily patronized by merchants.

Vibrant trade and agriculture in the transitional zone of the Indo-Gangetic plain eventually led to the birth of the Mauryan Empire with Chandragupta Maurya ascending the throne circa 320 BCE. He is said to have been assisted in this endeavour by his close adviser, Kautilya, and it is through his *Arthashastra*, a fine treatise on statecraft whose authorship and date of origin remains contested, that we glean more about migration in the ancient world.[24]

The first point to note in the *Arthashastra* is that ordinary people travelled considerably, for personal reasons, pilgrimages and fairs and festivals. This was in addition to those who led a life of travel such as traders and entertainers, though the latter were forbidden to travel in villages during the monsoon to avoid distractions during farm work. Most journeys were by foot, some on animals and carts, and there were official specifications on roads and charges for their use. Caravans of merchants paid escort charges and a road cess and boats could be hired for ferries. Special privileges were accorded to Brahmins who could travel free of charge. In fact, it was a punishable offence if they were made to pay the charges! Similar privileges were given to the *pravrajita* or wandering monks, men and women, though they had to carry a pass issued by the relevant authority.

Overall, migration was strictly controlled in the countryside and the fortified city through a chief passport officer, who collected a fee called *mudradhyaksha*. Different officers were appointed to oversee the safety of travellers and traders from thieves and wild animals. Village headmen were responsible for the traveller’s safety inside villages. Officers had travelling allowances included in their salary structures and were liable for compensation in case of robbery within their jurisdictions. Villagers were